

Nicolle Bekers, M.A.

Intermediate Team Faculty

Mary, Star of the Sea School

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Syllabus: 2026-2027 Grade 4 English

Mary, Star of the Sea School Mission

Nurture, Unite, Inspire. We are committed to nurturing each child's curiosity, uniting our classroom in respect and collaboration, and inspiring every student to grow in knowledge, faith, and wonder for the world around them.

2026-2027 Essential Question

"How can I model kindness, fairness, and humility like Jesus?"

Welcome to Grade 4! I am excited to partner with you this school year. This syllabus provides an outline of what we will learn, classroom expectations, grading policies, and the support you can expect throughout the school year. We will work together to create a class community where every student is encouraged, challenged, and inspired to grow academically and spiritually.

Schoolwide Learning Expectations (SLEs): Self-Aware, Confident Individuals; Teachable Life-Long Learners; Active Christians; Responsible Citizens

English Course Overview:

This course focuses on developing reading, writing, speaking, and listening skills. Students engage with classic and modern literature, explore grammar and vocabulary, and practice various forms of writing. Our primary focus is that every student develops a love for — and grade-level understanding of — books, writing, language, and grammar.

Standardized testing: Students take the STAR assessment in fall, winter, and spring to track growth. English-language learners take the WIDA assessment as required.

ENGLISH GRADING POLICY:

- 30% Assessments (Oral / Written Tests and Quizzes)
- 25% Classwork (Daily reading & writing practice)
- 20% Writing Portfolio (Published pieces & drafts)
- 15% Participation / Homework (Novel discussion, reading log)

- 10% Projects & Presentations

*Parents, please note: You will have access to my electronic grade book, via your Beehively account, which will be the method of communicating your child's academic performance. Beehively will serve as the primary source for monitoring grades, missing assignments, and academic progress throughout the school year.

Parent-teacher conferences: Formal conferences after Q1 and Q3 grades post. Additional conferences may be requested by email anytime.

REQUIRED MATERIALS:

Students should bring the following materials to English each day:

- Composition or spiral notebook (Reader's / Writer's Notebook)
- Erasable pen, pencil, eraser, and highlighter
- Sticky notes for annotating novels
- School-issued iPad (with access to Google Classroom)
- School planner

SUPPLEMENTAL MATERIALS — CORE NOVELS:

- Wonder — R.J. Palacio
- The Tale of Despereaux — Kate DiCamillo
- Inside Out and Back Again — Thanh Hà Lại
- Holes — Louis Sachar

HOMEWORK POLICY:

As per school policy, students are expected to allocate time for a maximum of 40 minutes of homework per night. Your child's 4th grade teachers will work together to ensure that the students receive a balanced homework regime aimed to create a positive learning environment that nurtures students' intellectual growth. Students are expected to record assignments daily in their school planner. Homework and important reminders will also be posted on Google Classroom for students and families. Parents are expected to check the student's planners daily, support their child in time management and follow through.

Late work will be accepted; however, submitting assignments on time is an important part of developing responsibility. Late submissions may affect a student's participation grade.

CLASSROOM EXPECTATIONS:

- Students come to class prepared and ready to learn each day.

- Homework should be completed on time. If circumstances prevent completion, students should communicate with the teacher in advance so that an appropriate plan can be made.
- Everyone is encouraged to participate by asking questions, contributing ideas, and seeking clarification from the teacher when needed.
- We will treat ourselves, one another, and school property with respect and responsibility.

Important Dates:

- Parent Orientation Night: August 12, 2026

Parent-Teacher Conferences:

- Fall: September 10–11, 2026
- Spring: February 19, 2027 (optional)

Expeditions:

- Q1 — Coconut Island: October 2, 2026
- Q2 — Pearl Harbor: November 16, 2026 (pending)
- Q2 — Ice Palace: December 14, 2026
- Q3 — 'Iolani Palace: March 5, 2027
- Q4 — Sherwood Forest: June 1, 2027

**All expeditions are subject to change at this point in the school year :)*

- School Spelling Bee: November 20, 2026
- Christmas Performance: December 18, 2026
- End-of-Year Awards: June 3, 2027

ACADEMIC INTEGRITY:

Honesty and integrity are essential values in our classroom. Teachers have the responsibility to:

- Structure conditions during testing to alleviate the possibility of cheating
- Specify the types of collaboration that are discouraged and those that are encouraged
- Teach students summarization of material and the distinction between summarizing and copying straight from the text

Students have the responsibility to:

- Avoid situations that might contribute to cheating or plagiarizing
- Avoid unauthorized assistance
- Use sources in the prescribed manner outlined by the teacher

ABSENCES AND TARDINESS

Students may remain at home in the case of illness, accident, quarantine, or because of a death in the family.

The teacher will help the student make up for missing assignments after a short absence. When the absence is expected to be prolonged, families must notify the teacher so that a plan can be developed for completing missing work. Repeated or prolonged absences might work against the student's academic progress and possibly the student's right to continue in attendance.

Students are marked tardy after the 7:45 a.m. bell rings. Explanatory notes from parents and conferences with parents may be advisable.

FOOD AND DRINK

- Food is prohibited in the classroom unless otherwise specified by the teacher.
- Drink in the classroom is limited to water in a bottle with a sealed lid.
- Sharing food is not permitted to ensure adherence to dietary restrictions.

TECHNOLOGY

- To minimize distractions and maximize learning, communication with students during the school day should be limited to emergencies.
- Student cell phones must remain off and in backpacks for the duration of a school day.
- This policy also applies to student smart watches (i.e., Apple Watches, Gizmo's, FiLiP's, etc.)

If a student is in violation of this policy, the discipline will be as follows:

- 1st Time Offense — Warning
- 2nd Time Offense — Phone will be sent to the office for student pick up from the Principal
- 3rd Time Offense — Phone will be sent to the office for student pick up from the Principal and parent will be notified

TEACHER CONTACT

- Contact me via email: nbekers@starofthesea.org
- Please allow up to 24 hours for a response on school days.
- In-person office hours: 2:45–3:15 p.m. (M–F) in Room B23

Empowered to Succeed, Guided by Faith